Though such strategies might appear unconventional for organizations with limited authority delegated by member states, they align with broader patterns in international cooperation. IOs frequently engage in democracy promotion, election monitoring, and judicial reforms as part of their mandates to foster global stability (Hyde 2011; Kelley 2012). Economic IOs like the IMF and World Bank have long encouraged governance reforms and transparency initiatives, a reflection of their broader role in spreading liberal norms championed by dominant powers like the United States and the European Union. However, these efforts can backfire, unintentionally consolidating executive power in ways that undermine democratic norms, as seen in cases of democratic backsliding enabled by external interventions (Meyerrose 2020).

IOs can also shape voter perceptions through endorsements and elite cues. For instance, research demonstrates that IOs' legitimacy often enables them to influence public opinion and policy. UN authorizations for the use of force, for example, tend to increase public support for military interventions (Voeten 2005), while EU conditionality has shaped party platforms and policy outcomes in various member states. In some cases, IOs have explicitly acknowledged their intent to undermine populist support, as the EU did when it passed strict migration measures to weaken populist momentum ahead of elections.[5]

6.1.2 Secrecy

While altering domestic political dynamics offers one route to sidelining populists' constituents, secrecy often provides a more straightforward approach. Populist leaders who genuinely distrust IOs or take anti-IO stances for political gain frequently face a tension between their stated anti-IO positions and the practical benefits IOs provide. Cooperation with IOs offers access to critical resources like economic assistance, dispute-resolution mechanisms, and security guarantees. However, engaging with IOs openly risks backlash from populist constituents who view such organizations as elite institutions infringing on national sovereignty. This is consistent with canonical research on audience costs in international relations (Fearon 1994; Trachtenberg 2012).